



ROCKET FUEL  
FACTORY

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# Doing More Without Adding Bodies

Global Sync Meetup NYC, 17 September 2026

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[therocketfuelfactory.com](https://therocketfuelfactory.com)

WHERE WE ARE

Whose vacation request do you dread approving?



**Which alert is noise.**

**Which client wants the details.**

**Which ticket gets a phone call.**

**Those are decisions, and they are not in any document.**

# Handing over the work is not the same as delegating

## WHEN YOU DELEGATE

- You hand them the queue.
- You wrote the rule down: call on any P1, and on anything from a client who has called twice.
- They check the ticket against that.

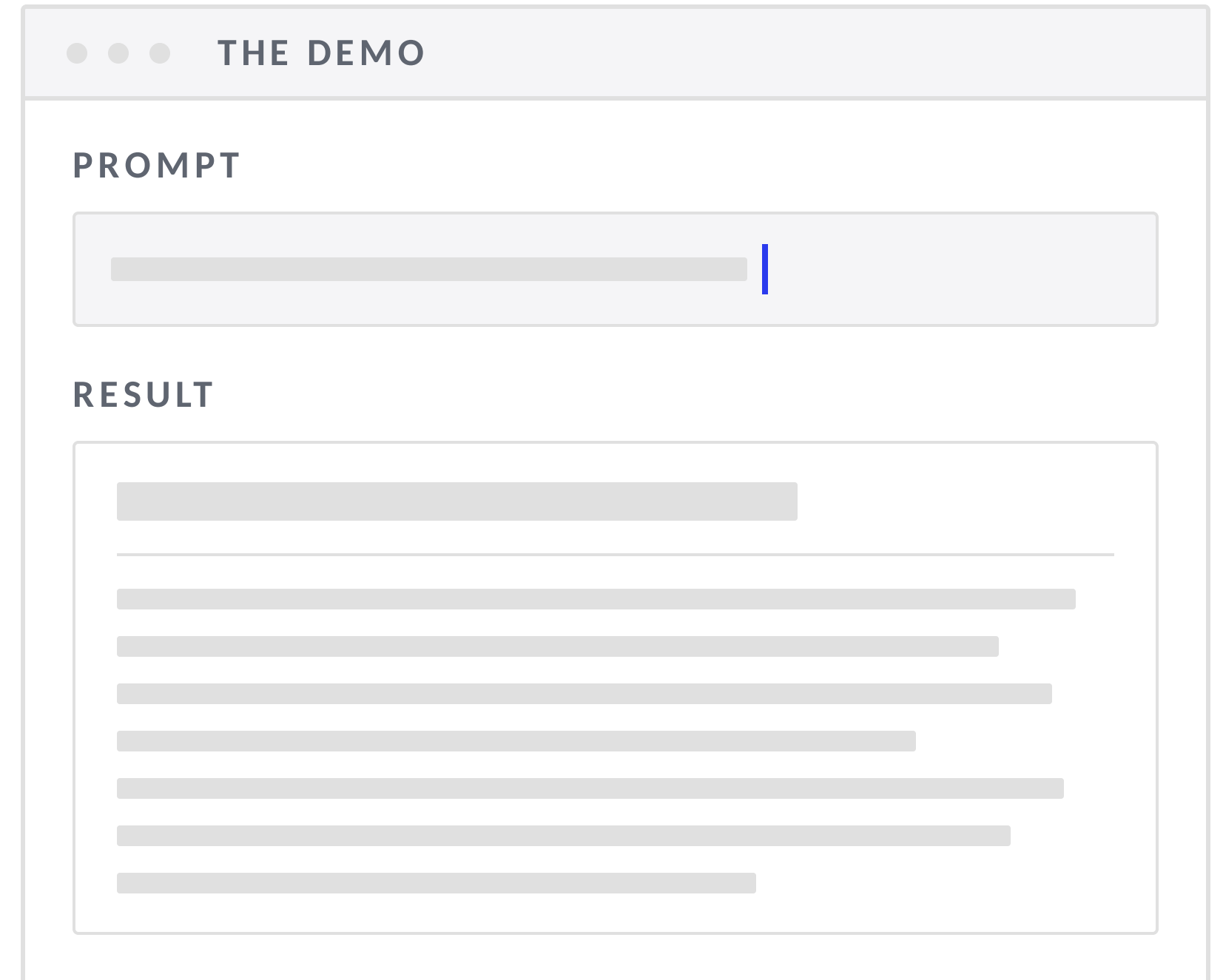
## WHEN YOU HAND OVER THE RULES TOO

- You hand them the queue.
- You left the rule to them: use your judgment.
- They guess, and with luck they guess right.

**Your best employees are the ones who usually guess right.**

# We expect AI to do wonders with a little instruction

- AI demos give a little instruction and show something beautiful built from it.
- Beautiful does not mean the details are where you want them.
- You already know what a junior tech does with a ticket that thin: real effort, a reasonable guess, and something you would not put your name on.
- AI does that too, without the pause where a person asks you a question.



# How most people prompt

| Write an email to the client about this. Apologize and let them know we're on top of it.

 <pasted from the PSA>

**Ticket #48213 - Harbor Dental - Dentrix down all sites**

|                                     |                     |                                        |  |
|-------------------------------------|---------------------|----------------------------------------|--|
| Status: Resolved                    | Priority: P1        | Opened: 09/12 08:47 by Dana W (client) |  |
| Contact: Dana Whitfield, Office Mgr | Board: Service Desk | Type: Network / Outage                 |  |

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                                  |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 08:47 - Dana called, front desk at Midtown and Riverside can't open Dentrix, main office is fine. Users getting "cannot connect to database server." She's pretty upset, says they have a full waiting room. Told her we're looking. | 08:52 - Tunnels from Midtown and Riverside to HQ FGT-60F are down. Phase 1 failing. Cert on the FGT expired 09/11 23:59. This is the same cert we flagged in the Q2 review that nobody approved the renewal on. | 09:10 - Regenerated CSR, submitted to DigiCert. Waiting on issuance.<br><br>09:48 - Cert issued. Installed on FGT-60F, rebound to IPsec Phase 1. |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

# What the client would have received

FROM Alex

TO Dana Whitfield

**Subject: Resolved – Dentrix Outage at Midtown & Riverside (Ticket #48213)**

Hi Dana,

I want to sincerely apologize for the disruption this morning at your Midtown and Riverside offices. I know a full waiting room with no access to Dentrix is incredibly stressful for your team and your patients, and I'm sorry we didn't catch this before it caused an issue.

**What happened:** A security certificate on your main office firewall expired overnight, which broke the secure network connection between HQ and the two branch offices. This prevented Midtown and Riverside from reaching the Dentrix server — the server itself and your patient data were never at risk or offline at any point.

**What we did:** Our team identified the cause within minutes of your call, issued and installed a renewed certificate, and restored connectivity. Riverside was back online at 10:12 AM and Midtown at 10:15 AM. We confirmed all three sites were fully operational before closing the ticket.

**Total impact:** Approximately 1.5 hours of intermittent access issues at the two branch locations. No data was lost or compromised.

**What we're doing to prevent this going forward:** **This certificate had actually been flagged for renewal in our Q2 review, and we're correcting the gap that let it lapse.** We're adding automated certificate expiration monitoring to our systems so we get advance alerts well before any certificate nears expiration — this will ensure we catch and renew these proactively going forward, rather than reactively.

Thank you for your patience this morning, and please don't hesitate to reach out if you have any questions or if anything seems off at any of the sites.

Best regards,

Alex

[Your Company Name] – Service Desk

**It leaked that line in two of three runs, and you had no say in which.**

# Ask it how to ask better

YOU

That's not the email I needed, and I don't want you to just take another swing at it. Look at how I asked you. What should I have told you up front so you could have written the one I had in my head? Teach me to ask better, not just to get a better email this once.

## THE MODEL

Fair. Here's what was missing, concretely:

- 1. Who's actually reading it, and what's their relationship to the incident**
- 2. What "on top of it" was supposed to mean, specifically**
- 3. Whether the Q2-review detail was a feature or a liability**
- 4. Tone register**
- 5. Whether there's a business ask riding along**

**Every one of those is a rule you already had in your head.**

# The same ask, with the rules written down

I need to send Dana Whitfield an email about this morning's outage. She's the office manager at Harbor Dental, three locations, and she's the one the front desk complains to. **She isn't technical and doesn't want to be. She'll forward whatever I send straight to Dr. Patel,** who owns the practice, so it has to stand on its own with no editing.

The ticket notes are below, but **don't quote them.** She doesn't need the equipment names or the timeline, and **she definitely doesn't need to hear that we flagged this cert in the spring and the renewal never got approved.** That's a conversation for me and Dr. Patel, not this

email. What she needs to know is that all three offices were down together for about 90 minutes, why in one plain sentence, that everyone was back by 10:25, and that no patient data was touched, because **that's what she asked me on the phone and what she's afraid of.**

The part I actually care about is what comes next. We're adding monitoring that warns us thirty days before any certificate expires, and it'll be in place by Friday. **That's what "on top of it" actually means, so say that. Do not use the phrase "on top of it" anywhere in the email.**

Keep it under 150 words, plain language. Own it without groveling. **Sign it from me, Alex at Northline IT.**



Ticket #48213 - Harbor Dental - Dentrix down all sites

SAME TICKET PASTED BELOW >

# A draft you can put your name on

|         |                                         |
|---------|-----------------------------------------|
| TO      | Dana Whitfield                          |
| SUBJECT | <b>This Morning's Outage — Resolved</b> |

Dana,

This morning's Dentrix outage at all three offices was caused by a network security certificate on our end that expired overnight. It's a straightforward fix once identified, but it did knock all three locations offline together, starting around 8:47 AM. Riverside and Midtown were back up by 10:15, and we had all three sites fully verified by 10:25 — about 90 minutes total.

No patient data was affected. The server itself was never down or at risk; the offices simply couldn't reach it while the connection was out.

We're putting in place monitoring that will alert us 30 days before any certificate is set to expire, so this specific failure mode can't catch us again. That'll be live by Friday.

Sorry for the disruption to your morning — I know a full waiting room makes this worse. Let me know if you have any questions.

Alex  
Northline IT

**Send**

**Those five questions work on any brief, to a person or a machine.**

## AHARON'S FIRST LAW OF AUTOMATION

# You can't automate a process that doesn't exist.



# A client's employee leaves while Mike is on vacation

OWNER Mike  
COMPLETED 6 of 6

- ☒ **Cancel software licenses**

To Chris, covering for Mike

To Mike

## Microsoft 365, Adobe, and the two tools he set up for that client

# Adobe Creative Cloud

**9 seats**

**A step is only documented if someone else can follow it without asking for help.**

# I keep seeing MSPs try to automate the wrong side of operations

## WHAT IS SOLD TO ANSWER THE CUSTOMER

An agent that answers the support line and opens the ticket.

An agent in the client's Teams, first message to closed ticket.

Password resets with no tech involved.

The quarterly review generated from the data.



## WHAT WE ARE ACTUALLY BUYING

**A phone that does not ring.**

**A ticket that closes without a conversation.**

**An end user we never have to talk to.**

**A review meeting we do not have to sit in.**

**Automate to give time back to the customer, not to hide from them.**

TWO MACHINES

# Which machine gets what



# What I hand to each kind of step



## DETERMINISTIC

Work with an exact rule, if this then that.

It does the same thing every time, so you check it once.

A gap in the rule shows up as an error.



## PROBABILISTIC

Work where a good guess is enough: drafting, sorting, summarizing.

It does something a little different every run, so someone checks every time.

A gap in the brief shows up in the answer.

**You already run a probabilistic system: a tech at 4pm on a Tuesday.**

# You can put AI in the middle of a process you wrote



DETERMINISTIC

1

Gather the facts from the systems that hold them.

2

Validate that it is complete and that we are allowed to act.

3

Attach the rules you wrote for this job.



PROBABILISTIC

4

Make the first pass: draft it, sort it, or summarize it.



DETERMINISTIC

5

Check it against those same rules, or hand it to a person.

6

Log what happened and tell the person who owns it.

**Tell it everything in writing before it starts, then check whether it understood.**

# The check is how you know it understood you

You check the answer against the same rules you wrote for the step, which is why writing them down mattered.

- Decide what a good answer looks like before you build the step.
- Ask for the answer in a shape a rule can test, like a category, a yes or no, or a number.
- Write down what went in, what came out, and who approved it, on every run.

## RUN LOG, THIS MORNING

|              |                                |                       |
|--------------|--------------------------------|-----------------------|
| <b>09:52</b> | Ticket 48213, outage email     |                       |
| OUT          | Draft, 138 words               |                       |
| CHECK        | Rules passed                   | <b>Alex sent</b>      |
| <hr/>        |                                |                       |
| <b>10:04</b> | Ticket 48219, printer          |                       |
| OUT          | Category: hardware             |                       |
| CHECK        | Rules passed                   | <b>Auto</b>           |
| <hr/>        |                                |                       |
| <b>10:11</b> | Ticket 48220, billing question |                       |
| OUT          | Draft, 212 words               |                       |
| CHECK        | <b>Over 150 words</b>          | <b>Held for Chris</b> |

When a client asks what the AI did with their data, you read them the run.

# Your customers have the same problem you do

They have a person the process lives in, and a month of work that only that person can do.

- Invoices that get retyped from one system into another.
- Approvals that wait on one manager's inbox.
- A month-end report built by hand from three spreadsheets.

## WHAT YOU GET FOR IT

- Hours you spend in front of them instead of behind a screen.
- A story about your own operations they watched you live.
- A new revenue stream that makes you harder to replace.



# Sit with one employee you would hate to lose



Ask them what they do at least once a month that they dread. Work out the unwritten process behind it and write it down. Then ask three questions. Could someone else follow it without asking for help? Could some or all of it be automated? Would that person feel threatened by that, or relieved?

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# Who was that

## Tim Fournet

Rewst  rewst

Builds automation for MSPs.  
Spent a long time being the  
person the process lived in.